only a detail.

Gertrude, David, and I went to New York on June 6, 1953, so that I could take in the various copies of The Caves of Steel. On June 8, I delivered a carbon to Mac, who promised me faithfully to give it back the next day at lunch.

I had lunch with Mac on the ninth and he did give it back. He was a pleasant person, good-humored and quick of understanding, with prominent eyes and the gift of gab, of moderate height and well dressed.

At this lunch, he looked even pleasanter than he ordinarily did, for he praised The Caves of Steel to the skies. He said that they couldn't use it for at least a year and a half, of course, since NAL would have to wait for publication first and then for an additional year. In the meantime, though, he wanted to do The Currents of Space, and he would be glad to let me have a $2,000 advance for its use.

I did my best to play it cool and not let him see how exciting that

was—$2,000 for doing nothing. To be sure, Doubleday would take $1,000 and Fred $100, but that would still leave me $900.

I said, "You understand, Mac, that Doubleday controls the rights and that you'll have to talk to them." Then I added, fatuously, "But I'll explain that I want you to have it and I'm sure that will settle that."

That afternoon, I called Walter Bradbury and could scarcely contain my excitement. "Brad," I said, "Mac Talley of NAL has offered me a $2,000 advance for paperback rights to The Currents of Space, so grab it fast."

There was silence at the other end of the phone, and just as I was beginning to wonder if Brad had fainted with joy, he said, "Isaac, Bantam Books has just offered a $3,000 advance for The Currents of Spacer

Now it was my turn to be silent. Finally I said, "What do we do?"

Brad said, "Did you commit yourself to Mac Talley, Isaac?"

"Yes, Brad, I'm afraid I did."

"In that case, we'll just have to give it to NAL."

I said urgently, "Listen, Brad. Doubleday would have gotten $1,500 of the